

Updated 1/13/2026

GEO330/GEO430/MPS604:
Sustainable Urban Transportation
Winter Quarter 2026
Group Project Rubric
C. Scott Smith, Instructor

Group project (Report 1 @ 10 points; Presentation 1 @ 10 points)

Students will work in groups of three or four to complete a report (and presentation) that will be handed in (and presented) at the end of the semester. The scope and methods of the report will be defined largely by group members under the supervision of the instructor but also enriched by occasional evaluations by peer groups. The overall approach should be either analytical or prescriptive in its design.

The subject matter of the report should address a socially relevant transportation issue in the city of Chicago aimed at advancing one (or more) of the three dimensions of sustainability.

The final report should contain about 10 double-spaced pages of text (approximately 2,500 words) including an introduction, background (literature review), methods or proposal, discussion and conclusion or recommendations sections along with a standard bibliography. To achieve standardization between group reports, I ask that a standard 12-point Times New Roman font be used with 0.5 margins.

My only recommendation with regard to the title is that the aim of your proposal should be clearly stated within it. The meat of the assignment will reside in background, method and discussion sections. The background section should describe in some detail an issue (or set of issues) that is somehow compromising sustainable transportation. The issue should relate to one or more of the problems we've discussed in class and how the problem manifests itself with respect to a particular context or area of concern. Further, I want you to discuss three dimensions of the problem; specifically how the problem compromises the economic, environmental and social welfare of the selected area.

The methods or proposal/solution section should identify the framework you used to either better understand or rectify a transportation-related problem. I encourage you to adapt the approach to a particular setting or context so that it has social value for the broader Chicago metropolitan area transportation community.

The bibliography section should list the source material you used to inform your work such as past research, plans, policies, reports, data, etc. I would like you to use a minimum of five professional sources to inform your proposal.

In addition to the written parts of the assignment I would like you to create several (five or more) original figures that in some way supports essential aspects addressed in your paper. Figures can be in the form of maps, designs, systems diagrams, flow charts or other figures that communicate complex information in a meaningful way. Again, I am giving you a fair amount of leverage here to individually decide what is appropriate although I highly recommend that you use your creative energy when producing your figures.

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To ease formatting of the bibliography and in-text citations, it is highly recommended that students use a reference management software application such as Zotero (free) or Endnote (the former will be discussed in class). Groups may wish to employ and/or expand on analytical approaches discussed in the lectures or presented in the weekly readings. I also advise that group members strategically select and coordinate their article reviews and field exercises as much as possible so that they collectively inform final reports. Lastly, I highly recommend that students use a cloud-based group authoring word processing program (and headings) to manage and streamline workflow.

Groups will present their work during finals week via a ten-minute presentation, including 3 minutes for feedback, questions and answers. All group members are expected to contribute and present content they assisted to create.